

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

An Enduring Advent ~ Joy
14 December 2025
Advent 3



Advent Starry Night 6 © 2017 Virginia Wieringa, viriniawieringa.com

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions...

We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Medley of Advent Carols:

CONDITOR ALME SIDERUM, BESANÇON, ANNUNCIATION, DIX,
VOM HIMMEL HOCH, TRURO, WACHET AUF, PICARDY, PSALM 42,
STAR OF THE COUNTY DOWN, MACHT HOCH DIE TÜR, VENI EMMANUEL

A Christmas Triptych (Traditional, arr. Samuel Milligan)

**Ellie Choate, Harp,
Christoph Bull, Organ**

Chiming of the Hour

The Lighting of the Advent Candles

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin & Juniper Fayazova

Advent Words of Gathering

Rev. Fregin & Juniper Fayazova

The Joy of God-With-Us does not come as naïve optimism, or surface level feel-good-ness. Joy cannot be imposed from on high. Joy cannot be commanded.

The Joy of God-With-Us is mingled with grief, exists side by side with mourning, knows that pain and death are all too real, but does not have the final word.

This joy tends...tenderly to beauty, and softness, and the gladness that comes from paying attention to what matters.

The Joy of God-With-Us is collective, liberating us from deadly despair.
Joy is gestating in sacred darkness; it comes unexpectedly.
Joy invites our expectation, and demands our participation.

Prepare the way, for joy with sorrow.

*May Joy be birthed among, within, and through us, this Advent.
O Come, O Come, Emmanuel...*

Please stand as you are able, in body or in spirit, for our Advent Hymn of Gathering

***Advent Hymn of Gathering**

Come Celebrate

ADESTE FIDELES

O Come, raise your voices!
Sing with joy and gladness!
Sing of the marvel and the wonder we know!
Born in the heart and shared the wide world over!
Come, celebrate the story!
Come, celebrate the story!
Come, celebrate the story;
the story of love!

Through countless trials,
in the bleakest hours,
over the barriers that lay in their way,
millions have carried light into the darkness.

We celebrate their stories!
We celebrate their stories!
We celebrate their stories;
the stories of love!

Wonder of wonders!
Strength beyond all knowing:
human compassion meeting needs in the world!
Ours is the task to carry on this story –
to celebrate the glory –
to celebrate the glory –
to celebrate the glory –
the glory of love!

[lyrics by Scott Kearns]

***Advent Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Michael Lehman

Holy One,
as we live in these days spun from a velvet darkness,
We greet this winter day.
Promises of wonder, delight, hope, and joy,
lie waiting for us to capture them
and make them real,
building a world that shimmers with beauty.

Into these moments between
receiving and giving,
may we weave a tapestry of life;
and as we cherish the gifts it has to offer,
might the beauty, truth, and goodness
that resides within us all -
be illumined with new meaning for each of us,
on this day and in all the days to come.

*As those born into love,
yet ever seeking it,
we offer ourselves to
your promise –
and to the joy of the Promised One.
Amen.*

[adaptlvf/ucc]

***Introit**

"Ding Dong! Merrily On High"
Cathedral Choir

CHARLES WOOD

***The Lord's Prayer**

Rev. Lehman

*Emmanuel, God-with-us,
Your name is beyond all naming.
May the gentleness of your loving reign take root upon earth;
May your heart's own longings unfold within us
and within all who wait for you in hope.*

*Sustain us, moment by moment,
with the strength to endure in our waiting.
Forgive us when we falter or wound,
and grant us grace to forgive
all those whose wounding has hindered our lives.*

*Spare us trials heavier than we can bear;
yet, in your tender mercy,
journey beside us through the sacred shadows of this season.*

*For in you rests the fullness of creation,
its illuminating light, holy power, and persistent love,
now, and forever. Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Fregin

God of Joy, who brought hope into this world,
be the hope that dwells around us.
God of Joy, who brought peace into this world,
be the peace that now dwells among us.
God of Joy, who brought love into this world,
be the love that dwells within us - and between us.

God of Joy, the solid rock upon which we stand,
be the center, the focus of our lives
on this day, and throughout this season of Advent.

On this day, may the Hope, Peace, and Joy of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Welcoming New Members & Celebrating Baptism

Rev. Lehman & Rev. Fregin

*Cathy Brown | Kelly Bryan | Lisa Domke | Clare Dong
Barklie Griggs | Gisele Hernandez | Dani Knight | Sereno Reid
Christina Walker | Hilary Wagner | Nick Wagner*

Baptism

Clare Dong | Harmony Jupiter

Beloved friends, we gather as one, woven together by the threads of love, justice, peace, and hope. Today, we are overjoyed to welcome these new members into our sacred community:

With open hearts and joyful spirits, we welcome you!

Each of you brings your unique story, faith, experience, insights, questions, enthusiasm, and gifts. Already, you are a blessing to all of us.

Together, we will welcome and celebrate your gifts, as we deepen our spiritual journeys, build community, and work for justice.

May you always find this community a place of belonging and acceptance, where you are known and cherished exactly as you are.

We promise to welcome and celebrate the fullness of who you are, and journey with you, celebrating your joys, and accompanying you in your struggles.

In the spirit of Christ's radical welcome, we say:

Welcome to the table of love. Welcome to the work of peace. Welcome to the church. You are home.

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition *from the Gospel of Luke*

Rev. Fregin

My soul proclaims your greatness, O God!

My heart rejoices in you, my Savior,

because you have showered your servant with blessing!

From now to the end of time,

all generations will know the great things you have done for me.

Mighty One! Your name is holy!

In every age,

your compassion flows to those who reverence you!

But all who seek to exalt themselves in arrogance

will be leveled by your power.

You have deposed the mighty from their seats of power,
and have raised the lowly to high places.

Those who suffer hunger,

you have filled with good things.

Those who are privileged,

you have turned away empty-handed.

You have come to the aid of your people,

in fulfillment of the promise you made to our ancestors—

when you spoke blessing to Sarah and Hagar

and all their descendants, to the utmost generation!

This is the Gospel of Grace.

Thanks be to God!

Reflection

An Enduring Advent ~ Joy

Rev. Lehman

Musical Gift

"A Ceremony of Carols"
Cathedral Choir, Ellie Choate, *Harpist*

BENJAMIN BRITTEN

Processional

Wolcum Yole!

There Is No Rose

This Yongë Child
Molly Pease, *Soloist*, Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Assistant Director*

Balulalow
Laurel Irene, *Soloist*

As Dew In April

This Little Babe
Dr. David Harris, *Director*

Interlude

In Freezing Winter Night
Katelyn Dietz and Frank Hobbs, *Soloists*

Spring Carol
Sharon Chohi Kim and Molly Pease, *Soloists*

Deo Gracias
Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Assistant Director*

Recessional

We offer deep gratitude to the 100+ people whose financial contributions have made this morning and the special music this year possible. If you would like to join them with a gift to music, please leave a note designating "music" on your gift.

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Fregin

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

Short Prelude in C Major, BWV 553/1 (ascribed to J.S. Bach)

Dr. Christoph Bull

***Advent Doxology**

THE FIRST NOEL

Praise God from whom all blessings flow
Praise God all creatures here below
Praise God above ye heavenly hosts
Praise Creator, Redeemer and Holy Ghost
Noël, Noël, Noël, Noël
Jesus is born, let us sing Noël.

***Prayer of Offering**

Rev. Lehman

Holy One, you encircle us and remind us that
each day brings a newness that we need but to step into.
It can wash us, lift us, heal us, hold us just as each of us has need,
so we pray:

*May we be open to the power that lies dormant
within us.*

May we be full with a confidence in our own strength
that we might see the joy in each day.

*May we move from the routines that we follow
to the fullness of life that we might live.*

With joy and gratitude we pray this and so much more,
Amen and Amen.

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Advent Words of Blessing

Rev. Lehman

Today, our hearts are filled with praise,
our lives are filled with joy,
our dreams are filled with hope,
and our world with promise
as together we decide to make it so.

*May we know the hope, peace, and joy of Advent
as the seeds which will grow in our lives
and nurture the promise of God's dream.*

We offer this as those who know a common joy!

*We offer this as a people
who are grateful.
Amen and Amen!*

***Hymn for the Journey**

"My Heart Sings Out with Joyful Praise"

ELLACOMBE

My heart sings out with joyful praise to God who raises me,
Who came to me when I was low and changed my destiny.

The Holy One, the Living God, is always full of grace
To those who seek their Maker's will in every time and place.

The arm of God is strong and just to scatter all the proud.
The tyrants tumble from their thrones and vanish like a cloud.
The hungry all are satisfied; the rich are sent away.
The poor of earth who suffer long will welcome God's new day.

The promise made in ages past at last has come to be,
For God has come in power to save, to set all people free.
Remembering those who wait to see salvation's dawning day,
Our Savior comes to all who weep to wipe their tears away.

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Vom Himmel hoch, da komm ich her (Friedrich Wilhelm Zachau) and Improvisation

Inside The Music

"Benjamin Britten left England in 1940 for a two year stay in New York. He was a conscientious objector, and concerned about life there.. In 1942 W.H. Auden wrote to him imploring him to return home. Auden said that they needed Britten's artistic voice and vision of peace to help guide them out of a dark chapter. Over the two week journey, he wrote "Ceremony of Carols" to poems he found in a book of Medieval poetry he bought on his journey. It quickly became a mainstay of the Christmas season. Originally written for treble ensemble and harp, he created an SATB version as its popularity grew. I'm struck by how the music immediately brings messages of hope, peace, love, and joy into focus. It simply feels like Christmas. Britten's masterful translation of life into art reminds us that we can be inspired by Christmas no matter what we're living through. Underneath the feelings of Christmas rest the justice that Christ's birth embodies. In the opening movements the promise of the season is well established. At the same time, we are invited to relate personally to it. As only Medieval poets can, we are challenged to ask ourselves if we are going to "attend to the song." In "Balulalow" we become Mary preparing the cradle and rocking the child. In "As Dew In April" we make the final pivot into the story with the words "I sing. . ." Now the justice of Christmas becomes ours to receive and be inspired by. "This Little Babe" was written by Robert Southwell, a Catholic priest living in England in the late 16th century. To be openly Catholic in Elizabethan England was to invite a death sentence. While living under that intense injustice, Southwell wrote a powerful justice message. The whole poem is crafted with martial language. The baby Jesus is cast into the fray with shepherds making muster, haystacks as spears, and his command post his stable crib. Each poetic turn reveals the subversion of earthly powers that Christ's birth portrays. Southwell says that we can "foil our foes with joy" through the child regardless of the powerful interests we have to overcome. In Britten's music we can feel the mounting tension. Each new phrase becomes more chaotic and frenzied. The struggle is real. And then those words of joy pop out of the texture. The voices are united through the seasons' reminder. Joy comes not from subverting others in this life, but from the love of a humble birth, the joys of sharing and communal exuberance, and the promise of peace. Now engaged, we are made to question our role in the world's continued injustices. "In Freezing Winter Night,"'s 5/4 meter creates an awkward jaunt, as if we're riding uncomfortably on a donkey. Christ's entry into the world, like so many children still today, was as difficult as it was miraculous. We are met with the question of why we would dedicate so many resources to wars and enrichment when children are starving. As we hear the wind biting in the music, we hear a sharp examination of our leaders and our collective priorities. In the next movement, all creation sings through divinity, and humanity is singled out as having the gift of praise. This leads to the final

movement where Adam, a placeholder for humanity, struggles with the bonds of life. Because humans take, we struggle, the poem teaches us. But in those human acts, there is also redemption. From each moment we fail to live up to the promise of Christmas, we can reflect and find renewal to take another step. The music ends as it begins saying that "Christmas is here, let's celebrate and remember that we possess the promise to bring Christmas into our lives and the lives of others.

A note about the words: The English language went through a radical transformation known as "The Great Vowel Shift" in the Medieval era. Many spellings and pronunciations of the language changed. The poems in this piece all come from this era. As such, some of the words will look and sound like a different language." -Dr. David Harris

Processional: Today Christ is born: Today the Saviour has appeared: Today angels sing on earth: Archangels rejoice: Today we exult, saying: Glory to God in the highest, Alleluia!

Wolecum Yole!: Wolcum, be thou hevenè king, born in one morning, Wolcum for whom we sall sing! Wolcum be ye, Stevene and Jon, Wolcum, Innocentes every one, Wolcum, Thomas marter one, Wolcum be ye, good Newe Yere, Wolcum, Twelfth Day both in fere, Wolcum, seintes lefe and dere, Wolcum Yole, Wolcum Yole, Wolcum! Candelmesse, Quene of bliss, Wolcum bothe to more and lesse. Wolcum, Wolcum, Wolcum be ye that are here, Wolcum Yole, Wolcum alle and make good cheer, Wolcum alle another yere, Wolcum Yole, Wolcum!

There is no rose: There is no rose of such vertu as is the rose that bare Jesu. Alleluia. For in this rose containèd was heaven and earth in litel space, Res miranda, (miraculous thing) By that rose we may well see there be one God in persons three, Pares forma, (in the parent's image) The aungels sungen the shepherds to: Gloria in excelsis, (Glory to God in the highest) Gaudeamus, (we rejoice).. Leave we all this werldly mirth, and follow we this joyful birth. Transeamus, (we follow).

That yongë child: That yongë child when it gan weep with song she lulled him asleep: That was so sweet a melody it passèd alle minstrelsy. The nightingalë sang also: Her song is hoarse . . . and nought thereto: Whoso attendeth to her song and leaveth the first . . . then doth he wrong.

Balulalow: O my deare hert, young Jesu sweit, Prepare thy creddil in my spreit, And I sall rock thee to my hert, And never mair from thee depart. But I sall praise thee evermoir With sanges sweit unto thy gloir; The knees of my hert sall I bow, And sing that richt Balulalow.

As Dew in April: I sing of a maiden that is makèles: King of all kings to her son she ches. He came also stille there his moder was As dew in Aprille that falleth on the grass. He came also stille to his moder's bour As dew in Aprille that falleth on the flour. He came also stille there his moder lay As dew in Aprille that falleth on the spray. Moder and maiden was never none but she: Well may such a lady Goddes moder be.

This little Babe: This little Babe so few days old, is come to rifle Satan's fold; All hell doth at his presence quake, though he himself for cold do shake; For in this weak unarmed wise the gates of hell he will surprise. With tears he fights and wins the field, His naked breast stands for a shield; His battering shot are babish cries, His arrows looks of weeping eyes, His martial ensigns Cold and Need, and feeble Flesh his warrior's steed. His camp is pitched in a stall, His bulwark but a broken wall; The crib his trench, haystalks his stakes; of shepherds he his muster makes; And thus, as sure his foe to wound, the angels' trumps alarum sound. My soul, with Christ join thou in fight; stick to the tents that he hath

pight. Within his crib is surest ward; this little Babe will be thy guard. If thou wilt foil thy foes with joy, then flit not from this heavenly Boy.

In Freezing Winter Night: Behold, a silly tender babe, in freezing winter night, In homely manger trembling lies. Alas, a piteous sight! The inns are full; no man will yield this little pilgrim bed. But forced he is with silly beasts in crib to shroud his head. This stable is a Prince's court, this crib his chair of State; The beasts are parcel of his pomp, the wooden dish his plate. The persons in that poor attire his royal liveries wear; The Prince himself is come from heaven; this pomp is prized there. With joy approach, O Christian wight, do homage to thy King, And highly praise his humble pomp, wich he from Heaven doth bring.

Spring Carol: Pleasure it is to hear iwis, the Birdes sing, The deer in the dale, the sheep in the vale, the corn springing. God's purveyance for sustenance, It is for man, it is for man. Then we always to give him praise, And thank him than.

Deo Gracias (thanks be to God): Deo gracias! Adam lay ibounden, bounden in a bond; Four thousand winter thought he not to long. And all was for an appil, an appil that he tok, As clerkes finden written in their book. Ne had the appil take ben, the appil take ben, Ne hadde never our lady a ben hevene quene. Blessed be the time that appil take was. Therefore we moun singen.

Cathedral Choir members

David Harris, *Music Director*, Fahad Siadat and Ianthe Marini, *Assistant Directors*

Miriam Adhanom*

Jennifer Almiron

Marie Ash

Cruise Berry

Yulia Bilous

Christin Byrdsong*

Beth Braun

Donald Brown

Martha Butler

Anna Caplan*

Matt Carlson

Carol Crawford

Ruthie Condren

David Conley*

Michele Delliquadri

Katelyn Dietz*

Chiany Dri

Sarah Fuhrmeister

Scott Graff*

Steve Gregoropolous

Linda Han

Brandon Harris*

Jeff Hindman

Tiffany Ho*

Frank Hobbs*

Jill Hornkohl

Laurel Irene*

Sharon Chohi Kim*

Paul Kolecki
Scott Lyness
Jim Maslowski
Amin Musavikhah
Bonnie Mitchell
Katie Norman
Christopher Parsons
Molly Pease*
Tanner Pfeiffer*
Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz
Rohan Ramanan*
Yin Ruan
Saginaw Rozzo
Meg Russett
Nandini Sadagopan
Alex Sandrotraconis
T.J. Sclafani
Ilsa Setziol
Grace Sheldon-Williams
Maggie Stillman
Ivanna Vargas
Anyia Vdovychenko
Jennifer Walls
Lorenzo Zapata*